Battlefield Centurion

The first time I heard people talking about the India–Pakistan fixture at Centurion Park on 1 March 2003 was exactly a year earlier, when some of my friends had been discussing it with great excitement. It was always going to be a huge game for both teams. The intensity was such that I could not sleep properly for three nights before the game. If there was ever a match we wanted to win, it was this one. The nation would brook no failure and for many of our fans this was the true final. It really did not matter to them what happened in the rest of the tournament, as long as we managed to beat Pakistan at Centurion.

The ground was buzzing hours before the match. It was sport at its best. This is why I played cricket, to be out in the middle for my team, on the world's biggest cricketing stage, against India's arch rival. Listening to the national anthem and singing the words gave me goose bumps.

Pakistan batted first after winning the toss and put together a very good score. Saeed Anwar held the innings together and made a very important hundred for his team. Their total of 273 was at least 20 runs more than we wanted to chase. As we were walking off the pitch, Sourav asked me if we should hold a brief team meeting. I said there was no need. Everybody knew what to do and it was now time to go out there and do the job.

During the break I hardly spoke to anyone at all. Nor did I eat much. In fact, for most of the time I had my headphones on and listened to music, trying to work myself into the right frame of mind. I just had a big bowl of ice cream and a banana to give myself some energy and asked one of the players to let me know as soon as the umpires had walked out to the middle. When they were in position, I picked up my bat and went out to start the run chase.

Generally it was Sehwag who took first strike, but this was a day with a difference. On the way out I told him that I would take strike and said that we needed to play out the initial burst from the Pakistani fast bowlers before we started attacking. Needless to say, Wasim Akram, Waqar Younis and Shoaib Akhtar were capable of doing a lot of early damage.

That's not how it turned out, however. In the very first over of our innings, I drove Wasim to the cover boundary. Then I took a single off